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God Is Merciful

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God Is Merciful

He withholds the punishment we deserve out of tender compassion.

The Lord, a Merciful God (Exodus 34:6-7)

“The Lord, the Lord, the compassionate and gracious God, slow to anger, and abounding in loyal love and faithfulness, keeping loyal love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin.” Mercy is not a later mood. It is the name God speaks over His own heart. He is slow to anger. He forgives. He does not give us the full measure our sin has earned.

The Blood and the Passing Over (Exodus 12:13)

“When I see the blood I will pass over you, and this plague will not fall on you to destroy you when I attack the land of Egypt.” Judgment was moving through the land. Israel was not spared because they were innocent. Mercy stood where the lamb had stood. The blow they deserved did not fall on that house.

A Broken Heart Not Despised (2 Samuel 12:13; Psalm 51:1, 17)

“I have sinned against the Lord!” “Have mercy on me, O God, because of your loyal love.... The sacrifices God desires are a humble spirit—O God, a humble and repentant heart you will not reject.” David’s guilt was real. His life was spared. Consequences remained. Mercy is not the pretense that nothing happened. It is compassion that does not despise the contrite.

Mercy on Nineveh (Jonah 3:10; 4:2)

“When God saw their actions—that they turned from their evil way—God relented concerning the judgment he had threatened them with and he did not destroy them.” Jonah said, “I knew that you are gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and abounding in mercy, and one who relents concerning threatened judgment.” The prophet fled from this very attribute. God did not. He withheld the ruin a violent city had earned when it turned.

“God, Be Merciful to Me” (Luke 18:13-14)

“The tax collector... beat his breast and said, ‘God, be merciful to me, sinner that I am!’ I tell you that this man went down to his home justified rather than the Pharisee.”

Mercy is asked for, not bargained for. The man who brought only his need received what the man who brought his record did not. God withholds condemnation from the one who has no claim but His compassion.

Daily Impact

Mercy is God not giving us what our sin has earned. That is first a door, not a slogan. The tax collector went home justified because he asked for compassion, not credit. David was not despised when his heart broke. Nineveh was not destroyed when it turned.

Daily this attribute teaches us to come quickly when we have sinned, rather than hiding until we feel presentable. It also searches the way we treat people. If God has been slow to anger toward us, we cannot be swift to crush someone else. Mercy does not call evil good. It refuses to take the last drop of payment when we have ourselves been passed over because of the blood.

Because God is merciful, I will come to Him when I have failed and show mercy to others.

Questions for Personal Application

1. Where am I still hiding from God as if He were only a Judge, rather than coming like the tax collector: “Be merciful to me”?
2. Whom am I refusing to pass over—holding a debt God has not required me to collect in full?
3. How should the blood on the door change the way I see both my guilt and my safety this week?
4. In what relationship do I need to be slow to anger because He has been slow to anger with me?
5. Whom can I invite to ask for mercy rather than to earn a hearing—someone who thinks they must arrive already cleaned?

Word Pictures of God’s Mercy

The Door Marked with Blood

Night has come, and judgment is moving through the land. Inside the house sit people who are no more innocent than the houses around them. They have not

argued their worth. They have taken a lamb, as they were told, and put its blood on the wood of the door.

Mercy is that door. The ruin they deserved does not enter. God is not pretending that sin is small. He is honoring a substitute He Himself appointed. When you stand in failure and expect the full blow to fall, this is the picture to see: not a God who cannot judge, but a God who passes over those covered by the blood.

The Hand That Does Not Finish the Blow

The guilt is not in doubt. The arm of justice is not weak. What mercy does is stay the stroke that could legally fall. “Slow to anger” is not slowness of mind. It is the Holy One refusing to spend all His wrath in a single hour.

He knows what we have earned. He does not always give it. That withheld blow is not permission to sin again. It is space to turn, breath to confess, a morning we should not have had. The same hand that could end us is the hand that lifts us when we have no claim left but His compassion.

The Tax Collector’s Only Sentence

Two men go up to pray. One brings a list. The other will not even lift his eyes. He beats his breast and says the only true thing he has: “God, be merciful to me, sinner that I am.”

Mercy is what meets that sentence. It does not bargain. It does not ask the man to improve the prayer until it sounds respectable. The one who came with need went home justified. The one who came with credit did not. When you have nothing to offer but the truth about yourself, you are not shut out. You are in the only place from which mercy is received.

Reflection

These pictures remind us that mercy is not God losing His nerve. It is God refusing to give us the full blow our sin has earned. A door marked with blood. A hand that does not finish the stroke. A man with one true sentence and no list. Because He is merciful, we stop hiding until we feel presentable. We take our place under the covering He has given. We ask for compassion rather than credit. And we learn to stay our own hand when we want the last drop from someone else.

1. Where am I still standing in an unmarked door—hoping to be spared because I am sorry, busy, or better than someone else—rather than under the blood God

has appointed?

2. Whom am I refusing to grant the withheld blow, when the Hand that could have finished me has given me another morning?
3. What would it mean today to pray only the tax collector's sentence, and to stop bringing a record God never asked me to read?

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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